

Colorado - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	A below-average but functional Power 4 team with a credible path back toward bowl contention: quarterback is more settled than either line.
Preseason consensus	Unranked; 0 votes/points · No conference-poll row supplied for Colorado · No. 66
Returning production	55% (No. 56) overall · Off. 57% (No. 59) · Def. 53% (No. 67)
Primer power rating	+0.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	4.7 wins · most likely 5-7
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ - Better, but modestly.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Brennan Marion gives Colorado a multi-back Go-Go offense built on varied formations, misdirection and backs who run/catch/block around full-time QB Julian Lewis; Chris Marve is rebuilding the defense around early-down run integrity, all-11 effort and a wave-rotation front.

Bottom line: Colorado should be more functional than the 3-9 2025 team and has enough quarterback/skill upside to threaten bowl eligibility, but a +0.5 power profile, open OL/DL competitions and heavy departure churn make five wins a more defensible center than a breakout assumption.

Beats expectations if: QB Lewis gives Marion efficient down-to-down quarterback play, the multi-back structure protects the offense from one-player dependence, and the OL/front competitions produce coherent first units by September.

Disappoints if: The unsettled OL repeats 2025 success-rate/havoc problems, the wave front cannot fix a run defense that ranked No. 135 traditionally, and new specialist operation costs field position/points; that leaves the Buffs around 3-4 wins despite Lewis.

Five things to remember

- 2025 baseline:** Colorado was 3-9 in 2025 and weak at the line of scrimmage: No. 135 rush defense, No. 129 offensive success rate and No. 128 havoc allowed.
- Quarterback:** QB Julian Lewis is the expected/full-time QB1; Isaac Wilson is a developmental backup/challenger, not a co-starter assumption.
- Coaching:** OC Brennan Marion is the offensive play-caller and DC Chris Marve calls the defense; both game-day calling roles are settled.
- Line rebuild:** Both lines are still being built in camp.
- ? Defensive availability:** LB Reginald Hughes is a material outgoing portal loss, but his 2026 destination remains unresolved.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	3-9 (1-8 Big 12)	● Very poor
Scoring	20.9 PPG	● Poor
Total offense	328.4 YPG	● Poor
Rush offense	125.6 YPG · 3.5 YPC	● Below average
Pass efficiency	6.80 YPA · 17 TD / 11 INT	● Below average
Third downs	38.4%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	30.5 PPG allowed	● Poor
Total defense	425.7 YPG allowed	● Very poor
Rush defense	222.5 YPG · 5.2 YPC	● Very poor
Pass defense	203.2 YPG · 7.55 YPA · 18 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

Colorado's 2025 offense was No. 116 in scoring and No. 114 in total yards, with a No. 104 rushing attack and No. 92 pass efficiency. The defense was worse at the point of attack: No. 112 scoring, No. 123 total defense and No. 135 rush defense, although pass-efficiency defense was a more respectable No. 69.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-2.38 · No. 85	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	-0.085 · No. 105	● Below average
Off. success rate	36.2% · No. 129	● Very poor
Off. explosive-play rate	11.6% · No. 84	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	19.4% · No. 128	● Very poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	-3.90 · No. 101	● Below average
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.016 · No. 72	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	42.6% · No. 81	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	14.6% · No. 128	● Very poor
Havoc created	14.2% · No. 99	● Below average

Advanced-stat read: Colorado's 2025 problem was consistency and line-of-scrimmage control more than a single catastrophic passing metric: offense ranked No. 129 in success rate and No. 128 in havoc allowed, while defense was No. 135 against the run traditionally and No. 128 at preventing explosives.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Deion Sanders - returning	● ↔ Head-coach continuity provides a stable program voice, but both coordinators and many high-leverage players are new.
OC / play-caller	◆ Brennan Marion - new external OC/QBs; offensive play-caller	● ↑ The Go-Go structure gives a clear schematic answer to a 2025 offense that struggled to sustain drives.
DC / play-caller	◆ Chris Marve - new external DC/LBs; defensive play-caller	● ↑ Marve is explicitly trying to rebuild early-down run integrity and the line of scrimmage, exactly where 2025 was weakest.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ WR Danny Scudero	San José State	● ↑ Major first-unit/rotation receiver candidate with Biletnikoff recognition; supplies immediate perimeter upside.
◆ WR Kam Perry	Miami (OH)	● ↑ Another Biletnikoff-recognized major receiver candidate; helps replace multiple outgoing WRs.
◆ OL Jayvon McFadden	Ohio State	● ↔ First-unit OL candidate from Ohio State.

Out	To	Loss
OT Jordan Seaton	LSU	● ↓ High-value tackle departure to LSU is a central reason the OL remains an open five-man competition.
WR Dre'lon Miller	Baylor	● ↓ Material receiver departure removes proven role volume.
WR Sincere Brown	NFL (L.A. Chargers), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Meaningful 2025 receiver exits via a confirmed Chargers UDFA signing.
OL Xavier Hill	NFL (N.Y. Jets), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Significant OL contributor exits via a confirmed Jets UDFA signing.

Offensive net: ● ↑ Better in quarterback/schematic clarity and receiver depth, but not clearly better at the line of scrimmage: the Go-Go skill package has upside.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Gideon Lampron	Bowling Green	● ↑ Projected major/starting linebacker with Bednarik and Butkus recognition; strongest newcomer recognition on defense.
◆ LB Liona Lefau	Texas	● ↑ Butkus-recognized linebacker with one of the strongest current role indicators in the room.
◆ DB Boo Carter	Tennessee	● ↑ Major secondary/nickel candidate whose versatility gives the rebuilt back end a high-upside role.
◆ DL Santana Hopper	Tulane	● ↔ Significant front-rotation candidate in the wave approach; valuable but not a declared fixed starter.

Out	To	Loss
LB Reginald Hughes	Transfer portal; destination not established	● ↓ Seven-game starter and Colorado's third-leading tackler is a material loss.
CB DJ McKinney	Notre Dame	● ↓ Material corner departure removes proven secondary value from a group still settling roles.
DT Brandon Davis-Swain	Texas A&M	● ↓ Meaningful interior departure contributes to the defensive-front reset.
DE Arden Walker	NFL (Minnesota), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Significant edge contributor exits via a confirmed Vikings UDFA signing.

Defensive net: ● ↑ Better in projected 2026 level than the No. 101 adjusted 2025 defense, but still highly uncertain.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	OC Brennan Marion's Go-Go uses multiple backs, varied formations and misdirection.	QB Julian Lewis is the defined QB1.	The OL five remains unsettled after a No. 129 success-rate and No. 128 havoc-allowed offense.
Defense	DC Chris Marve stresses all-11 effort and situational efficiency.	LB Liona Lefau and LB Gideon Lampron give the second level recognizable anchors.	The front remains unsettled while replacing multiple portal/pro departures.
Special teams	Newcomer snap-and-kick pieces after 2025 kicker turnover.	No strong unit-level edge is established in the signal set.	SP+ No. 116 and a new operation make execution variance a meaningful early-season risk.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B	● ↑	Medium-high	QB Lewis is the expected/full-time QB1 and Maxwell-recognized, giving Colorado a defined centerpiece.
RB	● B	● ↑	Medium	RB Welch returns and RB Young/Henderson/Smith/Taylor create a purpose-built multi-back Go-Go room.
WR	● B	● ↑	Medium	WR Joseph Williams returns.
TE	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	The room has a defined TE/fullback hybrid role and returning depth, but limited proven impact.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Low	OT Jordan Seaton and other losses are substantial, and the five remains unsettled.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↑	Low	The 2025 front was poor against the run.
LB	● B	● ↑	Medium	LB Lefau and LB Lampron both carry Butkus recognition and strong role indicators.
Secondary	● B-	● ↔	Medium-low	DB Boo Carter leads a talented but fluid group replacing proven contributors.
Special teams	● C-	● ↓	Low	SP+ ranks the unit No. 116.
Coaching	● B	● ↑	Medium-low	Sanders returns while Marion/Marve provide clearly defined systems and play-calling.
Overall	● C+	● ↑	Medium-low	SP+ No. 66 / +0.7 fits a below-average but functional P4 roster.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Julian Lewis	QB	● Established QB1 / breakout lever	Maxwell	The expected/full-time starter is the most stable high-leverage role on a roster.
Joseph Williams	WR	● Returning lead-target candidate	-	One of the few meaningful returning skill contributors.
Danny Scudero	WR	● High-upside transfer receiver	Biletnikoff	Major first-unit/rotation candidate and one of two incoming wideouts with Biletnikoff recognition.
Kam Perry	WR	● High-upside transfer receiver	Biletnikoff	Major first-unit/rotation candidate whose recognition strengthens the case for a better 2026 pass-catching group.
Liona Lefau	LB	● Potential defensive anchor	Butkus	Strong starting/major-role indicator and one of the two headline linebackers in Marve's reconstruction.
Gideon Lampron	LB	● High-end transfer linebacker	Bednarik · Butkus	Bednarik/Butkus recognition plus a strong current role makes him the highest-recognition defender.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Boo Carter	DB	● Versatile high-upside secondary piece	-	Major secondary/nickel transfer candidate whose versatility matters in a back end replacing several contributors.
Jayvon McFadden	OL	● Key first-unit OL candidate	-	One of the clearest named first-unit candidates in the team's biggest unresolved unit.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Moderate by national SOS rank but difficult for a +0.5 team.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · SP+ SOS No. 48
Hardest stretch	Texas Tech -> Utah -> at Oklahoma State -> Kansas State (Oct. 3-31, with an Oct. 10 bye): four straight conference opponents rated above Colorado, including top-10 Texas Tech and three more top-40 teams.
Swing games	at Baylor, Houston, at Cincinnati, UCF
Advantage	The Oct. 10 bye breaks the hardest stretch after Texas Tech, and the final three games (Houston, at Cincinnati, UCF) sit within roughly five points of Colorado's rating baseline.
Expected	4.7 wins; center 5-7
Floor / ceiling	3-9 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Colorado remains a high-attention team despite an AP zero-vote and SP+ No. 66 baseline; QB Lewis and the Go-Go installation can create narrative enthusiasm before the line-of-scrimmage questions are resolved.
Back them when	QB Julian Lewis is efficient, the OL keeps the offense on schedule and Marion's multi-back structure avoids obvious passing downs, especially against similarly rated opponents.
Fade/pass when	Pricing assumes a clean breakout before the OL/front prove functional, special teams remains unstable or the defense still allows explosive runs and poor early-down efficiency.
Key monitor	official OL five and interior alignment, defensive-front hierarchy, LB Reginald Hughes destination, secondary alignment, late-camp availability, new snap/kick operation
Week 1 baseline	Colorado +7.5 at Georgia Tech · rating-only baseline; Colorado primer +0.5 minus Georgia Tech primer +6.0 minus 2.0 default road/home-field adjustment; no matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Colorado +6.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Colorado has a clearer offensive direction around QB Julian Lewis and OC Brennan Marion's multi-back Go-Go structure, while the rebuilt defense has recognizable linebacker talent. That gives the Buffs a better functional floor than last year's 3-9 finish.

The limiting factors are still both lines, heavy roster churn and unstable special teams. Bowl eligibility is reachable if those groups settle, but 4.7 projected wins and a 5-7 center remain more defensible than assuming a clean breakout.

About this primer

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Sources: [OL update](#) · [DL update](#) · [2026 roster](#) · [Mack's Backfield Comes In Every Shape](#) · [QB update](#) · [coaching update](#) · [coaching update](#) · [Colorado Athletics report](#) · [2026 Football Coaches](#) · [transfer tracker](#)

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